



Anxiety and panic attacks

Explains anxiety and panic attacks, including possible causes and how you can access treatment and support. Includes tips for helping yourself, and guidance for friends and family.

What are anxiety disorders?

You can experience anxiety in lots of different ways. And there are some specific types of anxiety disorder. If your experiences meet certain criteria your doctor might diagnose you with one of these.

Some commonly diagnosed anxiety disorders are:

Generalised anxiety disorder (GAD)

This means having regular or uncontrollable worries about many different things in your everyday life. There are lots of possible [symptoms of anxiety](#). So GAD can be quite a broad diagnosis. That means the problems you experience with GAD might be quite different from someone else's experiences.

Social anxiety disorder

This diagnosis means you experience extreme fear or anxiety triggered by social situations. These might include things like parties, workplaces, or everyday situations where you have to talk to another person. It's also known as **social phobia**.

See our page on [types of phobia](#) for more information.

Panic disorder

This means having regular or frequent panic attacks without a clear cause or trigger. Panic disorder can mean you always feel scared about having another panic attack. This fear itself can trigger your panic attacks.

See our page on [panic attacks](#) for more information.

Phobias

A phobia is an extreme fear or anxiety triggered by a particular situation (such as going outside) or a particular object (such as spiders).

See our pages on [phobias](#) for more information.

Post-traumatic stress disorder (PTSD)

You might get a diagnosis of PTSD if you develop anxiety problems after going through something you found traumatic. PTSD can involve having flashbacks or nightmares. These can feel like you're re-living all the fear and anxiety you felt at the time of the traumatic events.

See our pages on [PTSD](#) and [complex PTSD](#) for more information.

Obsessive-compulsive disorder (OCD)

You may get a diagnosis of OCD if your anxiety problems involve having repetitive thoughts, behaviours or urges.

See our pages on [OCD](#) for more information.

Health anxiety

This means you experience obsessions and compulsions relating to illness. These include researching symptoms or checking to see if you have them. Health anxiety is related to OCD.

You can find out more about health anxiety on the [Anxiety UK](#) website.

Body dysmorphic disorder (BDD)

This means you experience obsessions and compulsions relating to your physical appearance.

See our pages on [BDD](#) for more information.

Perinatal anxiety or perinatal OCD

Some people develop anxiety problems during pregnancy or in the first year after giving birth.

See our pages on [perinatal anxiety](#) and [perinatal OCD](#) for more information.

You might not have, or want, a diagnosis of a particular anxiety disorder. But it might still be useful to learn more about these different diagnoses. It could help you to think about your own experiences of anxiety, and to consider options for support.

Living with GAD and panic attacks after losing my Dad



I really believe that talking is one of the best therapies you can have.



[Read Zoe's story](#)



It's like a swarm of bees just buzzing, buzzing, buzzing, not stopping. And making it impossible to focus and seemingly impossible to slow down and take a breath.



Anxiety and other mental health problems

It's very common to experience anxiety alongside [other mental health problems](#). For instance [depression](#) or [suicidal thoughts](#). You might have symptoms of both anxiety and depression but not fit one more clearly than the other. This might mean you get a diagnosis of 'mixed anxiety and depressive disorder'.



I have generalised anxiety disorder and depression which seem to come in cycles. I find the unexpected attacks the hardest.



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